

Contending for the Faith

I was born again at the end of the tent-revivalist era. It was my privilege to catch a few meetings by tent revivalists such as the late A. A. Allen and Leroy Jenkins, and I have been in Kathryn Kuhlman's meetings. As an ultra-Pentecostal holiness boy, some of the concepts they taught me about salvation confused me. I did not really know for sure that I was saved until I understood righteousness. No matter how well I did, the devil would come and tell me it was not good enough, and once again I would question my salvation.

I came in at the end of that tent era, and I saw God use some of these men in miracle-working power. In fact, we had an old A. A. Allen tape. He said, "What happened to you, little mama?"

She said, "I fell off a ladder, broke my back, and haven't walked in five years."

He said, "You haven't walked in five years? Have the doctors told you this?"

"Yes, the doctors told me this."

Then he would pray. You would hear him say, "In the name of Jesus." All of a sudden the crowd would start screaming, and he would say over the crowd, "There she goes, running across the platform." Then he would say, "Bring me another wheelchair." And he would do it again and again.

I had the privilege of seeing several of those kinds of miracles. But I did not understand the call on my own life. I did not know what to do with the intense hunger I felt inside, much less how to quench it or how to begin to answer the call.

I was working in the mills in Oregon. Sometimes after work I would go out with a baseball bat and pound pine trees because of the frustration. The call of God was so heavy on me, and I did not have the faintest clue how to answer it. I did not know how to enter in. I had no idea whatsoever.

That frustration built and built. I had seen these men work miracles, but I did not know how to enter in. I run into people all the time with that same hunger. Whether their call is helps, governments, or something else, some people carry an absolute, intense hunger to fulfill the ministry God has called them to. I used to be so frustrated because these men would preach about mighty miracles continually, but not one of them ever told you what to do, or where to begin, to get into a place where God could qualify you, give to you, and use you in those miracles.

Finally, one morning, God had mercy on me through a vision. I opened my eyes, thinking I was going to see the bedroom, but instead I opened my eyes to a vision. I saw a young woman preaching a meeting. She was doing beautifully, and the power of God was so heavy. I knew it was supposed to be my meeting, and for some reason I had not answered the call.

After several people got out of wheelchairs, she looked at me. The whole crowd disappeared. There was nothing left but me and her. She said, "I don't know why God has given me this ministry. One of you men must have failed."

That does not mean God does not call women. He calls women as He calls men. But in that vision, she had become a second choice because I had been a first choice. I may be a second choice for somebody else's first choice; I do not know. But I knew then that God had placed her in because I had failed.

When my wife woke up the next morning, I turned to her and said, "I can't take this anymore. Swim or sink, eat beans, sleep under a tree, I am going full time. Dress the kids in gunny sacks, live in the church, I don't care. I cannot live with this frustration anymore."

So I started reporting to the prayer closet. That is when I found out what nobody had taught me. I started reporting to the prayer closet at 5:30 or 6:00 in the morning when the mill whistle blew, because I figured that if I was going full time, I was going to put in the hours I would normally put in at the mill. I reported to an eight-by-eight prayer closet in the church and locked myself in.

First, I exhausted myself praying in English. Then I switched over to praying in tongues because, number one, I was a Pentecostal holiness boy. At that point I had been filled with the Holy Ghost, and I knew I could speak with tongues. However, there was a conflict among the elders about whether a person could speak in tongues any time he wanted to. Well, I elected that I could, because I did not know how else to spend those untold hours I had committed to in the prayer closet.

I would last 15 or 20 minutes in English, and then I would switch over. I would sit on the floor praying in tongues, or walk back and forth in that eight-by-eight room praying in tongues, simply because I did not know how else to spend the time I had locked myself in there for. It was in that closet that God taught me what nobody else had taught me up to that point.

I had been so hungry, like many of you, that if anyone told me to do something and said it would bring more of the miracle-working power of God into my life, I was more than willing to jump and do it, because I did not know the Word. That hunger made me a victim for every wind of doctrine that came along.

One group said, "No wonder you don't walk in power. Look at all that jewelry you are wearing."

It was not very much, just a watch and a ring. But they said, "No wonder you are not walking in power. You are wearing jewelry."

I said, "This jewelry is keeping me from walking in power? I'll take it off." So I took it off. Before I took it off, I was a powerless jewelry wearer. After I took it off, I was a powerless non-jewelry wearer.

The next group that captured me said, "No wonder you don't walk in power."

I said, "Why not?"

"How were you baptized?"

I said, "In the name of the Father, and of the Son, and of the Holy Spirit."

They said, "You've been baptized into three gods. There is only one God, and you have been baptized in the name of three of them."

I said, "Well, what do I do?"

They said, "You must be rebaptized."

I said, "That's fine with me."

It was the middle of winter, and the pond was frozen. It did not make any difference. Bathtubs just would not do. That did not sound religious enough, being baptized in a bathtub. Somehow, even the comfort of a swimming pool would not do. If there was no suffering involved, you would drag a tire down there, light it, burn it, and crack the ice.

I will never forget the man who was doing the baptizing. He got in, and he turned blue. Everything showing turned blue. I thought, Uh-oh. He wanted me to get in and help him. Well, I jumped in first. He grabbed hold of me, and I was shivering, frozen stiff. I was a powerless Pentecostal boy baptized into the name of three gods. He shoved me under. I came up absolutely frozen stiff, a powerless Pentecostal boy baptized into the name of one God.

So anything anyone told me, if it promised to fulfill the hunger inside my heart, I would say, "How high and how far do I jump?"

Now, I understand your hunger is different from mine. You are not called to the same thing. But what I cannot understand is any person not having a God-hunger that drives him all the way into relationship with God. That part I cannot understand.

So here I am, reporting to the prayer closet. Can you imagine how I felt later when I read Jude 3 and saw that, by the power of the Holy Spirit, there is an exact way to begin the contending process for the faith that was once delivered to the saints?

Beloved, when I gave all diligence to write unto you of the common salvation, it was needful for me to write unto you, and exhort you that ye should earnestly contend for the faith which was once delivered unto the saints.

For there are certain men crept in unawares.

After 17 years of meditation, God has confirmed and reconfirmed this point: Paul, Jesus, or any other teacher inspired by the Holy Spirit will never tell you to do something without also going on, in detail, to tell you how to do it.

It is not enough to know that I should earnestly contend for the faith once delivered to the saints. My heart's cry was, "For God's sake, would somebody please tell me how to contend?" That had been my heart cry for seven years of ultra-Pentecostal holiness. It is not enough to know that I

should contend. Somebody has to tell me how.

Notice that Jude said you and I should earnestly contend for this kind of faith. When I found out the kind of faith the early church walked in, I said, "My God, we have a lot of contending to do."

Well, that is what we have been doing. Correct me if I am wrong, but when I came to church this morning, did you notice people lying along the driveway on couches and in wheelchairs, hoping that your shadow or mine might fall on them when we got out of our cars so they would be healed? Or did you and I come in on the wrong road?

Yet in a revival in the early church, they lined the sick up in the streets so that perhaps Peter would come down that street and his shadow would overshadow some of them and they would be healed. They came from the cities round about with every disease conceivable to mankind, and it says they were healed, every single one.

Now Jude tells you and me to contend for the faith that was once delivered to the early saints, because already, by the time the epistle of Jude was written, men had crept in unaware and begun to destroy the faith of the early church. If he said this faith is contendable, then it is contendable.

Whoever these men were, they destroyed faith. That made me meditate on this chapter over and over, for no other reason than to find out what traps not to fall into for the destruction of my own faith.

Do you know what I found? Jude called the men who crept in unaware "clouds without water." He called them trees twice dead, plucked up by the roots. They were dead once, then they got born again and became alive. Then they were deceived and lost their salvation: twice dead.

He labeled them as clouds without water, waves of the sea raging and foaming out their own shame, and wandering stars. They come out of darkness in a blaze of glory and put on quite a show, but just as quickly as they appear, they disappear back into the darkness they came out of. They come out of the sea of people, put on a display, and then disappear back into the ocean they came from.

But by far, my favorite label Jude put on the men who destroyed the faith of the early church is "clouds without water." They come over the horizon, look good, and sound good. There is just one problem: when they get overhead, they cannot produce because they have no water.

We do not have to worry about that. We are clouds with water. From Genesis to Revelation, any time the Holy Spirit is likened to anything, He is likened to water. Jesus said that if you believe on Him as the Scripture says, out of your belly, out of your spirit, out of your innermost being, will flow not one river, but rivers of living water.

Thank God. The first criterion for contending for the faith once delivered to the early saints is that I must be full of the Holy Spirit. He is the One who can properly wage this contending in my life. He is the only One qualified, from the inside out, to mortify the things that keep me from properly contending for the faith. The first stipulation is that I must be a cloud with water.

We are. So look closely at Jude 19. It says, "These be they who separate themselves." Who are the "they" he is talking about? If you do not take it out of context, he is talking about the clouds without water, the trees twice dead and plucked up by the roots, the waves foaming out their own shame. Jude says, "These be they who separate themselves."

Then he gives the description:

These be they who separate themselves, sensual, having not the Spirit.

These are the clouds without water and the wandering stars. They separate themselves because they are sensual, having not the Spirit. That tells me that having the Holy Spirit is absolutely essential if I am not going to be dominated by my senses. Somehow the Holy Spirit plays a role in the basics of prayer so I am not dominated by sensuality. The question is how.

They are controlled by the carnal nature. In the basics of faith, you would call them people who are more moved by what they see, hear, and feel than by what the Word of God says. Jude says they are sensual, sense-dominated, and they separate themselves.

Separate themselves from what? Jude is telling us to earnestly contend for the faith once delivered to the saints. If he is telling us to contend for that faith, then what are these men separating themselves from? If it is not the doctrine in the original creeds set forth by the apostles, then what is it?

These men are sensual, dominated by carnality, and separating themselves from the doctrines of the apostles because they do not have the Holy Spirit. So what is it about having the Holy Spirit that makes me not a candidate to be separated from the truth?

You know as well as I do that Jesus commissioned the Holy Spirit. He said that when He is come, He will guide you into all truth. He said, "Thy word is truth." And concerning those who deceive you, the Scripture says you have no need that any man teach you, because the anointing you received from Him abides within you, is truth, cannot lie, and will teach you all things.

That does not eradicate the office of teacher. I would not have a job. But concerning those who seduce you, you have no need that any man teach you. What if I am the one seducing you through teaching? How will you know the difference? That anointing within you teaches by the inner witness, by mysteries and revelation knowledge concerning the Word and concerning those who would seduce you.

This is why Jude 19 and 20 are one thought, my friend. They should never have been separated in our thinking:

These be they who separate themselves, sensual, having not the Spirit.

But ye, beloved, building up yourselves on your most holy faith, praying in the Holy Ghost.

These are sensual clouds without water. They look good, sound good, and can carry on a religious program, but they have no water. But you, beloved, can build yourself up on your most holy faith by praying in the Holy Ghost.

Build myself up where? Above susceptibility to deception, above being ruled by the sensual and carnal nature, above that whole mess, on my most holy faith. How? By praying in the Holy Ghost.

Let's take it down one level, from separation from apostolic doctrine into error, to the basics of faith. If we faith people had a creed, everybody else does. Foursquare has its creed. The Assemblies of God has its creed, its bylaws. Every organization has a creed, a list of what it believes and does not believe.

If we faith people had a simple creed, it would be this:

I am not moved by what I see, hear, or feel. I am only moved by what I believe, and I take the Word of God as the final say-so in my life.

That would be our creed.

"Yes, but you are sick."

Who asked you? If you ask my body, it will tell you. I know it will. That is how the thing is made. It has sensory organs, and they report to my brain. When my body is invaded by disease, those senses say, "You are sick." That is why I am not asking my body for the final say-so.

"Are you saying you are not sick?"

That is right. I am not asking my body for the final say-so. My body will tell me the exact condition it is existing in, but that does not help me much when it disagrees with the Word. So I am not asking it.

"Who are you asking for the final say-so?"

I am asking the Logos, the Word of God. I am asking the Holy Spirit. Jesus said, "My words, they are spirit, and they are life." If you try to separate Jesus' words from the Holy Spirit and His relationship in your life, you are wasting your time, my friend. The only thing in this earth the Holy Spirit will represent is Jesus' words, because they are spirit and they are life.

If you ask the Holy Ghost, He will give you the same answer. If you ask Jesus, He will say, "I am the Logos, the origination of the Word. I closed the gap between humanity and the mighty Jehovah. I was the communication that revealed God to man. If you have seen Me, you have seen the Father."

It does not matter who you ask. They will all say one thing: the Word of God is near you. You can believe in your heart the Word of faith which we preach. You can believe in your heart that God raised Jesus from the dead, confess it with your mouth, and be born again. You can also say with

your mouth and believe in your heart that the mountain is gone, and it shall be removed into the sea.

Ask anybody or anything the Word of God, and it will all say the same thing: two thousand years ago your disease was nailed to the cross. It is not up to God anymore. It is up to you. It is now your choice.

So I am not asking my body. I am asking the Word of God. My disease was nailed to the cross some two thousand years ago, and I am simply going to say what the Word of God says about it. If we faith people had a creed, that would be it: I am not moved by what I see, hear, or feel. I am only moved by what I believe, and I take the Word of God as the final say-so in my life.

But I have to admit, it takes the walk of the Spirit to execute the final say-so of the Word in your life. Otherwise your carnality will cancel you out.

When I first started praying in the Holy Ghost and getting indoctrinated to the Word of God, I listened to so many Copeland and Hagin tapes that I finally got to where I could preach Kenneth Hagin's testimony better than he could. I thought he was leaving too much out. "When I was a young Baptist boy on a bed of affliction, God healed my body." Then he would go into details about what side of the room his bed was on and whether his bedroom was on the west, north, south, or east side of the house. I could preach his material so well.

I still can. Then Copeland came along, the bold culmination of faith rolled up in one man, stomping around on the platform and threatening the devil. I had never seen anything like it. So I listened to his tapes until I could preach his material as well as he could.

There was just one tiny, insignificant, minor problem. Like most of you, I could make this faith stuff sound a whole lot better than I could make it work.

It is not that I wanted it that way. I did not. Do you think I liked disease tracking me down and cleaving to my body? "Why didn't you stop it?" Well, I told it to stop.

How many love it when poverty tracks you down and overtakes you? Your paycheck gets smaller, your hours get fewer, and the bills get bigger. Have you ever noticed that when your check decreases, the money-taking incidents increase? They cut your pay and you have six flat tires that month. As the old saying goes, when it rains, it pours.

Do you think I liked poverty tracking me down? I did not like it at all. Do you think I liked disease cleaving to me? I did not like that at all. Did I tell it to get away? Yes. Several times. But it still tracked me down.

Thank God I discovered this: those who are sensual are more moved by what they see, hear, and feel than by the Word of God. But Jude said, "You, beloved," because you have the Holy Ghost, can build yourself up above the kind of walk where you are dominated by what you see, hear, or feel.

I barely made it full time. I was scared and intimidated. I had three little kids: David, Bill, and Steve. I had to support them. I had no meetings. Nobody wanted to hear me preach. Why not? Because I had never preached before. Yet I could not stay on the job because I was too consumed. That vision panicked me, so I went full time.

Shortly after that I received Hagin and Copeland tapes, and I listened and listened. They built me up in faith and established my foundation in righteousness. I found out I was the righteousness of God in Christ by the rebirth, not by earning, but by grace. I found out I was saved. When I had problems, I could run into God, not away from Him.

Then He taught me the walk of the Spirit. I found out He had made me righteous, saved me, and seated me in heavenly places with Christ Jesus. Then He taught me how the power of the Holy Spirit could be activated in my life to mortify the flesh, so I could clothe myself with the inner man, which is created after Him in righteousness and true holiness.

I found out that by praying in the Holy Ghost and mortifying the flesh, I could literally clothe myself with the nature of righteousness I had received as a free gift on the inside. First He gave me the foundation of faith: saved by faith, the righteousness of God in Christ, and the promises belonging to me in the past tense. Then He taught me the foundation to lay on top of that one: the walk of the Spirit. That is how the characteristics of my flesh began to change until the fruit of the Spirit started coming forth in my life.

When I first went full time, I had three little kids. We were living on a shoestring. It was horrible. Some nights shortly after I went full time, I would wake up in a cold sweat and sit straight up in bed. This horrible fear would rack me. I could see my kids dressed in gunny sacks and going hungry.

At one point I broke down under it. We went and got some food stamps, and after all the hassle to get them, we were going to stand in that welfare line. But I went home and said, "I can't. I can't. I cannot." I turned around and gave them to a neighbor. They went down and got food with them. We just skipped it. I could not do it.

I did not know what to do. Faith was just beginning to come to me through the tapes, and I was just starting to go down and spend those hours praying in the Holy Ghost. I did not know what it would do to my faith. I did not know it would begin to build me up.

My God, I admired the Word. I admired being able to stand up in the face of poverty and speak the Word of God to it, and to speak to disease that was trying to cleave to my body. But intimidation and uncertainty would overpower me. I would drop out of executing His Word and just worry and worry.

Not knowing what else to do, I continued in prayer. I kept praying, and it kept building me up on my most holy faith. I was lifted above the sense-dominated realm until confidence began to come. In the first two or three months of prayer, I found myself standing up and not falling out; I was able to speak the Word of God with more boldness and not quit doing it.

Once I made a contract with God and prayed the Word, buddy, I would stand on it like the Rock of Gibraltar. You could not move me off of it because my senses were being strengthened and fortified by the edification coming up from within, simply because I had accidentally begun to spend hour after hour praying in the Holy Ghost.

A lot of you fall short right there. You have seen people who were highly trained in faith, able to use the Word, and yet they were consumed by disease and died. We see this happen. One of the main reasons is that we fall short of executing the Word in its fullness. We do not have the edification and stamina that comes from praying in the Holy Ghost, the stamina to stand there, all night long if necessary, and describe the victory the Word has wrought over the problem.

Even if a disease is eating your body from the inside out, most of the time we do not receive because we fall short in executing His Word. We have not employed the other part, the edification that frees our senses from fear until we actually believe what the Word says.

My God, we have a revelation. It is not going to fail me. If Mark 11:23-24 says I can say to this mountain, then cancer, you may think you are going to kill me, but you are not. I have prayed in the Holy Ghost, and I am edified enough to believe what His Word says about my problem.

If I had to stand here all night and describe the victory over my body, I would be here. I do not care if I lose my job or all of it. If I am dying, I am going to take the hours to turn my body back into victory. Most of us fall short, throw up our hands in fear and dismay, and worry takes us out. We are not confessing the Word. We are not standing on it.

Listen. Jude says you can build yourself up above that sense-dominated realm, where your senses dominate you and even dominate what you believe about the Word of God. How do you know your senses dominate you? Because you do not do the Word. If you did the Word, I would say they do not dominate you.

If I were dying, or if my budget were being consumed and I were worried about it, do you think I would go to bed next to that thing in anything but peace? Are you kidding? I would plant my feet on the rock and describe the victory of the Word over that problem until it turned. The reason I would do it is that I would be edified enough from praying in the Holy Ghost to believe it would turn because I was standing there saying it.

Why lie down next to a problem? Why let it run over you? These are they who are sensual, sense-ruled, having not the Spirit. But you, beloved, can build yourself up above that by praying in the Holy Ghost.

I am going to stop with this testimony.

There is an exhortation of love in this: "In Me, you can have peace beyond anything you could compare, because there is a holy place in Me where your senses will not threaten you. When you enter in, you will find Me there. It is a wonderful place, a place of victory, a place of joy."

So I reported to the closet. After about two months, a little gal found out what I was doing. She came hopping by and said, "Are you feeling any difference?"

I said, "Yes, ma'am. Real dry throat, real tired chin, and tired tongue from praying all those hours in the Holy Ghost."

She said, "Excuse me, I've got to go."

About three months went by, and I was locked up in prayer. The same girl came by and said, "Our church is having a lay witness." That is where the laymen of the denomination come together in a certain church, in this case in our city, and testify to the wonderful things God is doing in their lives.

Now remember, they did not believe in speaking with tongues. She came by because she was a member of that church, but she had spoken in tongues. She had been baptized under our ministry and had spoken with tongues. So she asked if I would like to go to a home-cell teaching meeting that morning.

I was so excited. Listen, I would have taken advantage of any opportunity to get out of the prayer closet. I ran home, changed my clothes, and got there just as they were breaking up the fellowship because a golden-tongued orator was going to speak that morning. I had been listening to Hagin and Copeland tapes, and now I was going to hear a real live flesh-and-blood man speak.

I arrived late, so they asked, "Do you want anything to drink? He is going to start."

I said, "Yes, bring me some coffee."

They brought me coffee, and I sat down. There was an elderly lady sitting next to me. The golden-tongued orator began. "We know that Jesus is the great celestial go-between the troubled waters of mankind and the untroubled God..." If his notes had been in scroll form, they would have rolled all the way down through the living room. This guy had his message down.

I sat there thinking, My God, what did I get myself into? I eventually got so bored I started shaking my coffee for excitement and watching the little rings work their way to the edge of the cup. That is bored. Out of sheer boredom I started looking around, just like some of you do when you do not want to listen to the message and your mind is somewhere else.

I had no idea what was about to happen. You have to understand, I had just spent three months in prayer. Out of sheer boredom, I looked at the elderly lady next to me. When I did, I knew it was inside my spirit, but it was so clear it looked like God stuck an X-ray between me and her. It was of a hip section. The hip section was dark, and it extended three or four inches down into her leg.

I sat there looking at it. I could see through it and see her on the other side, and it just stayed on her. I thought, My God, what is this? I did not feel any anointing. Nothing. I was bored. I looked at her, blinked real hard, and it stayed there. Pretty soon I started praying under my breath, "Oh my God, what do I do? God, do You want me to pray for this woman? What do You want me to do?"

To make a long story short, I went on and messed up that prayer meeting as they knew it. Badly. Later, while preaching at Grace Fellowship and laying a foundation for understanding how to begin to walk in power, I used this testimony.

While I was using that testimony, God interrupted me and said, "I can tell you why I let you go on and destroy that service as they knew it while the orator was orating."

I said, "I would really like to know."

The Holy Spirit said to me in the middle of the message, "If I was not listening to that golden-tongued orator, why should I make you?"

So I turned to the lady and said, "Ma'am, do you have problems in your right hip?"

Before I could say anything else, the word arthritis just jumped out. I said, "It is arthritis. You have arthritis in your right hip."

She said, "Why, young man, that is what the doctor tells me."

Now, I had arrived late because I went home to change. I did not know she had come in on a crutch. The crutch was in the corner. She was sitting next to me, and I did not know.

When she said, "That is what the doctors tell me, young man," I said, "Glory to God."

She said, "I beg your pardon?"

I said, "No, I mean you are going to be healed. Do you mind if I pray for you?"

Later I found out that for her, prayer meant, "Sometime in the course of your day, would you please bow your head and remember me?" That is all prayer meant to her. That is not what it meant to me.

When she said, "Yes, you may," I jumped around in front of her and grabbed both her ankles. I got on my knees while she was sitting in the chair, and I pulled her ankles up even with my stomach. I looked down and one leg was two or three inches shorter than the other because of that hip.

I could not watch. I was too moved by what I saw. So I closed my eyes and looked away. The golden-tongued orator noticed the commotion and sent his associate to break it up. As he started across the room, I started praying my hardest Pentecostal holiness prayer.

I said, "In the name of Jesus."

I did not want to look, but the witnesses told me that at the first "Jesus," it cracked and popped and came out. She was completely healed, but I did not know that. I was afraid to look. Before they could stop me, I nearly wrestled that poor lady out of her chair and onto the floor trying to get her healed.

When the golden-tongued orator arrived to break it up, he saw the miracle instead. It affected him so badly that it struck him dumb. He could hardly talk.

Then the orator wound up his message with this: "What is the most outstanding sequence of events that can possibly be attributed to the God factor in your life?"

His associate was saying, "Over here. It is over here."

They tried to tell that lady God had not done it, and she chased them around with her crutch. That afternoon at the dinner, she stood up and said, "If God did it for me, He will do it for you," and wound up her testimony. For some reason, I was not invited to that dinner.

There was also a woman under therapeutic care who could not bend over. They called me at home and said, "Can we come to your house?"

I started to say, "Round her up and every sick person you can find, and bring them." But the Holy Ghost said, "Main auditorium. You go down to the church."

So I went down to the church. Would you believe they tried to bring me to a room in the basement that was so far below ground it had sump pumps in it? Talk about hiding a guy away. They were just going to let me pray for her down in that room. But the Holy Ghost kept saying, "Main auditorium or nothing."

So I said, "Main auditorium or nothing." Finally, after they took a break, they brought me in front of the main auditorium.

They were sitting around fellowshiping, and the man who had seen the miracle saw me standing there. He said, "He wants to say something."

I thought, He does? What am I going to say? I did not know what to say. Finally they politely looked my direction. That is when the Holy Ghost fell on me. An anointing gripped me like a vise. I heard myself saying things so good that I knew I was not that smart. I wanted to step out of my body and take notes.

I thought, My God, this is good. Where is this coming from? It affected those people the same way. They started creeping toward me, eyes wide, not wanting to take their eyes off me. They felt for their chairs and sat down, waiting to see what I would do next.

I started telling them the testimony, and suddenly I saw another vision. A man was sitting three or four rows back on the end. I marched up to him, and he looked at me and leaned as far away from me as he could.

It was too late. I had a vision of his shoulder. I saw the diseased shoulder, and he could not lift it up. I grabbed him by the wrist and said, "In the name of Jesus!" He cried out, then said, "My God, it doesn't hurt."

I said, "You bet your boots, buddy. What do you expect?"

I did not know what was on me. It was a gift of faith. The gift of faith makes you bold as a lion and floods your senses with a God-reality. When you are standing in front of somebody in a wheelchair, you start thinking like God. You think, Why leave them in it? Then you have all the confidence in the world. That is a gift.

Later that night I thought, My God, I could have been standing there with a broken-off arm in my hands. I will never do that again. I did not understand the gift of faith. I could just wake up, as it were, with this arm in my hands.

The woman who could not bend got healed. One boy's cataracts came off. Pretty soon all the rooms emptied out, and I yelled, "Anybody want what I got?" All the youth came up and started getting filled with the Holy Ghost. People were running around wanting to take their pulse because they had never seen people under the power before. I hardly had either.

Anyway, I left them in that commotion. I slipped out a side door and found a post. I was so in the Spirit. It was my first experience like that. I leaned on that iron post, and the Spirit of God started pouring through me and prophesying. I could hear Him.

He said, "Son, this did not come on you because it was ordained from the foundation. I would have given this to you a long time ago if I could have. Nor did it come in respect to your evangelistic call. A lot of evangelists do not walk in any of it. Nor did it come in respect to creed, color, race, or anything else. You uncovered a spiritual law, and you operated it for three months."

You see, praying in the Holy Ghost builds you up on your most holy faith, above a sensual, carnal, dominated walk, above being moved by what you see, hear, or feel. It brings you into a glorious place where, year after year, you become willing, absolutely willing, to take the Word of God as the final, absolute, unrestricted say-so in your life.

Mark 11:23 says you can say to the mountain if you do not doubt in your heart. Thank God, you and I have found something we can do that affects the human heart, the very part of us He said not to doubt in. He said you can say to the mountain, and if you do not doubt in your heart, you will have whatever you say with your mouth.

After 17 years, He is still bringing me to a place where I am ready and willing to prostrate my entire life on one single verse, a place in the Holy Ghost where you do not fall short of believing it until what it says comes to pass. That is walking not according to your senses.

As we wind down on these basics of prayer, you know that in the prayer center we are contending for exactly the kind of faith once delivered to the early saints. There are two ways in this contending. One is contending as the Body of Christ, as the prayer center, as we meet together collectively, share the Word, hold one another up, and pray for one another. The other is individual. Individually, concerning this aspect of prayer, you cannot pray in tongues too much.

Collectively, when we meet together as the Body, as a corporate structure in which we are individual members, God desires at times to use our corporate mind as we fill this auditorium together in prayer. He desires to flow through us and put all of us on something He wants prayed out. Corporate prayer is as important as individual prayer. It knits us together.

If you have been hearing a voice that says, "Do not come to corporate prayer anymore; just pull aside and spend private time before God," that is a voice of separation. It is a lie from hell, and it will not work. You need corporate prayer as much as you need individual prayer, just as much as

you need a body of believers to go to church with instead of walking out the rest of your life by yourself.

It is the same standard. We need to gather together, and we need to incorporate a strong individual prayer life.

Now, in closing: God is not impressed with your 6:00 to 7:00 early morning prayer any more than He is impressed with your 9:00 to 10:00 hour of prayer that night. Nor is He particularly impressed with the night we choose to come together as the prayer center to pray. He enjoys any time you spend with Him, but He is not keeping a tally.

Sometimes we spend three days in prayer and then miss two. Then condemnation comes because we missed the two. But He is not keeping a tally. You can pray two days in a month and not pray anymore, and God is still not keeping a tally.

Let me tell you the part He fellowships with. It is not your legalistic hours from 6:00 to 7:00 or 12:00 to 1:00. He fellowships with the change prayer produces in your life. If you only prayed three hours last year and it produced something wonderful in you, then He comes into your room and fellowships with whatever it produced, because you invited Him in. He does not condemn you for the other hours you did not spend in prayer.

That does not exclude the fact that if you spend every day in prayer, it will produce more change that He can fellowship with. But if you do not, He does not condemn you for what you did not do. If you only spent one hour last year in prayer, and He can find something it changed in you, He will come and fellowship with that change because you are His child.

Hallelujah. As a corporate Body, we have the Word together, we gather and praise together, and we go to church together. Then there is our individual walk, when we meditate the Word, pray, speak the Word, fellowship with God, and spend our individual times praying in tongues.

We need both. If any voice is telling you to exclude one or the other, it is not God. Hallelujah.